

The Nixon Administration

Richard Nixon assumed the presidency in January 1969, believing he could force Hanoi to negotiate, while also reducing US troop levels in Southeast Asia. Within a year, he was as frustrated with the war in Vietnam as his predecessors had been.

◀◀ BEFORE

Americans hoped that the election of Richard Nixon would end the Vietnam War.

THE OLD NIXON

As vice president in the 1950s, Nixon had a reputation for being a **tough anticommunist**. He had urged President Eisenhower to use US troops and airpower in Indochina. Even after losing the 1960 presidential election to Kennedy, Nixon supported the new administration's decision to **increase American aid to South Vietnam**.

PROMISES OF PEACE

While campaigning for the presidency in 1968, Nixon suggested he had a **secret plan to end the war**. He promised "peace with honor" and created the expectation that he could end the stalemate and make Hanoi capitulate.

Nixon's initial efforts to end the war were as much improvisation as grand strategy. The president and his national security adviser, Henry Kissinger, guided the nation's foreign policy. Nixon was a veteran politician and Kissinger was an Ivy League international relations scholar. They shared a penchant for secrecy and crafted US policy in Vietnam without significant input from others. They had no blueprint for success in Indochina but they were confident that one existed and they would find it.

The Madman Theory

Both Nixon and Kissinger were convinced that diplomacy and the use of force had to be better coordinated. On January 25, 1969, they expanded the peace talks that Johnson had begun in Paris to include representatives of North Vietnam, South Vietnam, and the Viet Cong. Shortly afterward, on March 18, the US secretly began to bomb North Vietnamese military sanctuaries in neutral Cambodia. Nixon called this dual strategy the Madman Theory. He told Chief of Staff H. R. Haldeman that he wanted the North Vietnamese to believe that he was unpredictable and dangerous, a rampant anticommunist with his hand on the nuclear button. Secretly, the Nixon administration called the plan Operation Duck Hook. They deliberately leaked to the press that Nixon planned a "go for broke" air and naval assault to inflict punishing blows on North Vietnam.

The Silent Majority

On March 19, the administration announced the introduction of Vietnamization, a plan to increase the combat role of the South Vietnamese while reducing the number of Americans fighting the ground war. Such a prospect was widely welcomed by the American public, which was growing restless about the high cost of fighting the war, in terms of both human lives and resources. However, those who opposed continued US intervention in Vietnam were not willing to wait for de-escalation.

In October, large and peaceful antiwar protests occurred throughout the country. To counter this public pressure and to shore up his image of determination, on November 3, Nixon made one of his most memorable public addresses—his Silent Majority speech, claiming that the antiwar protesters represented a minority that was prepared to surrender to tyranny.